September 10th (against British and Cuban cargo ships) and October 7th (on the island). On September 27th another CIA sabotage team was arrested in Cuba. At an October 4th meeting of the Special Group (Augmented) another decision was taken "to step up operations including the dispatch of sabotage teams into Cuba." In the following days three more meetings followed to discuss this, including, Garthoff notes, "one on October 16th in between two meetings in the White House that day on the missiles in Cuba."[59]

The most important attempt was the failed attack at the Matahambre copper mine. A first attempt failed in late 1961 when technical problems prevented the boat carrying the commandos from arriving; the second attempt, in the summer of 1962, was met by a Cuban militia patrol and forced to flee. The third attempt, in October 1962, was also repelled by Cuban troops – on October 22nd, just as President Kennedy was announcing the presence of Soviet missiles on the island, and denying that Cuba could possibly have any need to defend itself from U.S. aggression. One participant in the raid heard Kennedy's speech from his boat off the shores of Pinar del Río, where he was waiting for two missing infiltrators to return.[60]

Though the Cubans were able to prevent the October attack on Matahambre, they could not prevent a November 8th attack which blew up an industrial facility and, according to Castro, killed 400 workers. The team which had carried out this raid was arrested on November 13th. Castro protested in a letter to the U.N. Secretary General: "The capture of the leader of a group of spies trained by the CIA and directed by it, here in Cuba, has shown us how the photographs taken by spying planes serve for guidance in sabotage and in their operations and has also revealed, amongst other things, a desire to cause chaos by provoking the deaths of 400 workers in one of our industries."[61]

On the eve of the Cuban Missile Crisis, MONGOOSE was criticized for its slow progress. At a meeting in October 1962, according to notes taken by Richard Helms, "Robert Kennedy, in expressing the 'general dissatisfaction of the President' with MONGOOSE 'pointed out that [MONGOOSE] had been underway for a year … that there had been no